

Week 9: Nigerian Art and Culture

JSS1 Nigerian History — First Term Lesson Note (Deep-Dive Edition)

Introduction

Nigeria's many peoples have produced a rich and varied artistic and cultural heritage for centuries. This week explores traditional art forms, festivals, and how they contribute to Nigerian cultural identity.

Traditional Art Forms

Art Form	Description/Examples
Bronze and brass casting	Skilled metalworking traditions from Igbo-Ukwu, Ife, and Benin, producing sculptures, plaques, and ceremonial objects
Terracotta sculpture	Clay figurines, famously associated with the ancient Nok culture
Wood carving	Carved masks, stools, doors, and figures used in ceremonies and daily life across many ethnic groups
Textiles	Handwoven and dyed cloth such as Aso-oke (Yoruba) and Adire (Yoruba indigo-dyed cloth)
Beadwork	Decorative beads used in royal regalia and personal adornment, especially among Yoruba royalty

Nigerian Festivals

Festival	Associated Group/Region	Significance
Eyo Festival	Lagos (Yoruba)	A masquerade festival honouring deceased traditional rulers
Osun-Osogbo Festival	Osun State (Yoruba)	An annual festival honouring the river goddess Osun
Argungu Fishing Festival	Kebbi State (Hausa)	A festival celebrating fishing skill and community
Durbar Festival	Northern Nigeria (Hausa/Fulani)	A colourful horse-riding display, often marking Islamic celebrations
New Yam Festival (Iri Ji)	Igbo communities	An annual festival celebrating the yam harvest

Cultural Identity

Traditional art and festivals are not simply decorative — they carry deep meaning, preserving history, religious belief, and communal values. They help each ethnic group express and pass on its unique identity, while together contributing to Nigeria's overall national cultural richness.

Real-Life Application

Many of these traditions continue today: Adire cloth is still handmade and worn in modern Nigerian fashion, the New Yam Festival is still celebrated annually in many Igbo communities, and traditional masquerades still appear at major cultural festivals across the country.

Vocabulary

Word	Meaning
Masquerade	A costumed performer, often representing spirits or ancestors in traditional festivals
Regalia	Ceremonial clothing and ornaments symbolizing status or office
Cultural identity	The sense of belonging to a particular culture or group, shaped by shared traditions

Evaluation Questions

- 1 List three traditional Nigerian art forms.
- 2 What is Adire, and which ethnic group is it associated with?
- 3 Name one festival associated with the Igbo people, and explain its significance.
- 4 What is the Argungu Fishing Festival, and where is it celebrated?
- 5 Describe the Durbar Festival and its cultural context.
- 6 What does the Eyo Festival honour?
- 7 Explain the difference between terracotta and bronze/brass casting as art forms.
- 8 Why are festivals considered important for preserving cultural identity?
- 9 Give a real-life example of a Nigerian cultural tradition still practised today.
- 10 In your own words, explain how art and festivals help pass on history and values across generations.